STIVEN CATALYST

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MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



PEOPLE

ONBOARDING THAT KEEPS PEOPLE

How few organisations onboard well, how early jobs end, Bauer's four C's, what a buddy and a manager change, and a card for the first weeks of a new person.

12% of US employees strongly agree that their organisation does a great job of onboarding new employees (2017 report).

GALLUP, 2018

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In this issue

The first weeks in a job shape whether a new person settles in. This issue looks at what those weeks give them: the rules, a clear role, the culture and, above all, people.

Only 12% of US employees strongly agree that their organisation onboards new people well, and only 29% of new hires feel fully prepared afterwards. Of the jobs that Americans born 1957–1964 started at 18–24, on average 61% ended within a year. Talya Bauer sums up onboarding in four C's. A meta-analysis of 70 samples finds that role clarity, confidence and acceptance by colleagues carry its effects, and at Microsoft new hires who met their buddy more often felt productive sooner.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

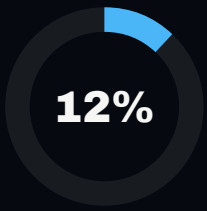
Our reading
Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

Only 12%

Gallup asked US employees whether their organisation does a great job of onboarding new employees. The answer comes from its State of the American Workplace report of 2017.



strongly agree that their organisation onboards new employees very well.

29%
of new hires feel fully prepared and supported to excel after onboarding

2.6×
as likely to be extremely satisfied at work, for those who call their onboarding exceptional

OUR READING

Onboarding is not a first day. It is the months in which a person learns the role, the place and the people.

Sources: Gallup, 2018; Gallup, 2019

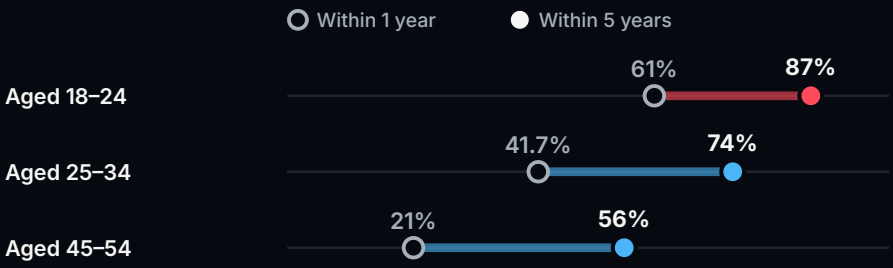
The 29% and the 2.6 times come from a Gallup paper of 2019; the second is a correlation, and the method is not shown.

THE NUMBERS

How early jobs end

The US Bureau of Labor Statistics has followed Americans born 1957–1964 since 1979. For every job they started, it records how long the job lasted.

SHARE OF JOBS THAT ENDED, BY AGE AT THE START OF THE JOB



On average they held 12.9 jobs between the ages of 18 and 58. The figures count every way a job ends: people who quit, layoffs and contracts that run out.

OUR READING

A large share of jobs ends within the first year, above all for the young. That year is exactly where onboarding works.

Source: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2025

One US generation; the shares are averages per person. For Albania and Germany we have no comparable data.

THE MODEL

The four C's

In a guide for the SHRM Foundation, Talya Bauer describes onboarding in four building blocks, from the rules to the relationships.

01	**Compliance**	The basic legal and policy rules.
02	**Clarification**	The tasks and expectations of the role.
03	**Culture**	The organisation's norms, formal and informal.
04	**Connection**	The relationships with people at work.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A NEW SHIFT LEAD'S FIRST WEEK

Compliance	Safety briefing and contract on day one
Clarification	The three numbers the shift is judged on
Culture	How a mistake is reported here
Connection	Lunch with the buddy, coffee with the night lead

Each C has an owner and a day. The plan is invented.

OUR READING

The first two C's can be handed over on paper. The last two only happen between people.

Source: Talya N. Bauer, SHRM Foundation, 2010

The four C's follow Bauer (2010); the example is the editors'.

More in the essay “Watch how I do it” is not training

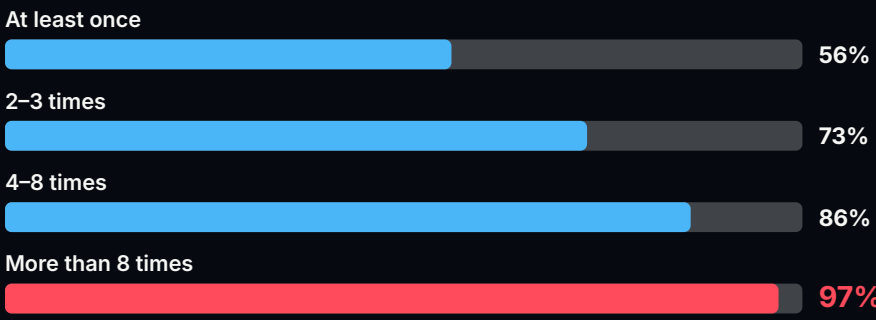
WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Clarity, confidence, acceptance

A meta-analysis of 70 samples of new employees, by Talya Bauer and colleagues, found three links between what an organisation does and how a new person fares: role clarity, confidence in one's own ability and acceptance by colleagues.

Through them, onboarding goes with job satisfaction, commitment, performance, the intention to stay and lower turnover. At Microsoft, a pilot involving 600 employees gave new hires a buddy.

NEW HIRES WHO SAID THEIR BUDDY HELPED THEM BECOME PRODUCTIVE QUICKLY, BY MEETINGS IN THE FIRST 90 DAYS



OUR READING

A buddy is not a programme. It is a person with time in the calendar, and the meetings are what count.

Sources: Talya N. Bauer et al., Journal of Applied Psychology, 2007 (via Abstract (PDXScholar, PubMed)); Dawn Klinghoffer, Candice Young & Dave Haspas, Harvard Business Review, 2019

Microsoft's figures are self-reports from one company, written up by its employees; the first group includes the others.

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Measure the first 90 days

Onboarding can be measured like any process: on fixed days, with the same few questions, for every new person.

1. **Day 30, 60 and 90**
   A short conversation on fixed days, booked on day one.
2. **Three questions**
   Is the role clear? Do you feel able to do it? Do you feel accepted by the team?
3. **Count the buddy meetings**
   How often did the new person and the buddy actually meet?
4. **See who stays**
   Of everyone who started, how many are still here after 6 and 12 months.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, TEN NEW HIRES IN ONE QUARTER

Day 30	8 of 10 say the role is clear
Day 90	9 of 10 feel accepted by the team
12 months	8 of 10 still here

The two who said the role was unclear on day 30 are the ones to talk to first. The numbers are invented.

Source: Talya N. Bauer et al., Journal of Applied Psychology, 2007 (via Abstract (PDXScholar, PubMed))

The steps and the example are the editors'; the three questions follow Bauer et al. (2007).

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The first-weeks card

One card for one new person, filled in by the manager before the first day. At Google, managers got a similar list by email on the Sunday before a new person started.

01 Before day one documents ready; the talk about the role and its responsibilities booked

02 Buddy name, and how often they meet in the first 90 days

03 People to meet five names, and why each one matters

04 Check-ins once a month for the first six months: the dates

05 Open questions how and when the new person can ask anything

06 Day 90 role clear? able to do it? accepted by the team?

Sources: Laszlo Bock, 2015 (via Excerpts quoted by readers and summaries); Talya N. Bauer, SHRM Foundation, 2010

A practice proposed by the editors, after Google's five actions for managers (Bock, 2015) and Bauer's four C's.

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

Why the Onboarding Experience Is Key for Retention
Gallup, 2018
https://www.gallup.com/workplace/235121/why-onboarding-experience-key-retention.aspx

Create an Exceptional Onboarding Journey for Your New Employees
Gallup, 2019
https://www.gallup.com/workplace/247091/create-exceptional-onboarding-journey-new-employees.aspx

Number of Jobs, Labor Market Experience, Marital Status, and Health for those Born 1957-1964
U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2025
https://www.bls.gov/news.release/archives/nlsoy_08262025.htm

Onboarding New Employees: Maximizing Success
Talya N. Bauer, SHRM Foundation, 2010

Newcomer adjustment during organizational socialization: A meta-analytic review of antecedents, outcomes, and methods
Talya N. Bauer et al., Journal of Applied Psychology, 2007 · via Abstract (PDXScholar, PubMed)
https://doi.org/10.1037/0021-9010.92.3.707

Every New Employee Needs an Onboarding "Buddy"
Dawn Klinghoffer, Candice Young & Dave Haspas, Harvard Business Review, 2019
https://hbr.org/2019/06/every-new-employee-needs-an-onboarding-buddy

Work Rules!
Laszlo Bock, 2015 · via Excerpts quoted by readers and summaries

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked "via". The editors' interpretation is marked "Our reading". Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.

Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

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